

Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work

A hands-on beginner course in Adobe Photoshop. Over eight sessions you fix, grade, retouch, composite, design, and automate, finishing one real piece every session, then plan, build, and present a portfolio piece of your own.

FORMAT**Instructor-led****DURATION****8 sessions · 24 hrs****SESSION****3 h incl. a break****LEVEL****Beginner**

HOW THE COURSE RUNS

One module, one 3-hour session, one finished deliverable. The course is built as eight modules (0 to 7), and every module already ends in a finished piece: a fixed photo, a clean photo, a graded photo, a portrait, a composite, a poster, a batch, a portfolio piece. So the schedule follows the modules instead of cutting across them. Each module's lessons (framing, a live demo, a hands-on lab, and a quick self-check) add up to about 2¼ to 2½ hours, which fits a three-hour session with a break, a recap, and a gallery or critique of the finished pieces. Nobody goes home with half a project, and every session starts from a clean slate.

The two ends of the course use their time differently. **Module 0** is a single short lesson, so Session 1 also covers orientation, a setup check, and a workspace tour, and runs the first win twice: once on a practice file, once on your own photo. **Module 7** is a self-directed capstone: you choose your brief at the end of Session 7, plan and build most of it as homework, and Session 8 is for plan review, a final studio block, presentations, and peer critique.

Weekly: one session a week for eight weeks. The week between sessions is for practice on your own photos and your learning journal.

Twice a week: four weeks. Keep at least one day between Sessions 7 and 8 for the capstone build.

4-day intensive: two sessions a day (morning and afternoon). Hand out the capstone briefs at the end of Day 3 so the plan and most of the build happen before Day 4.

FOUNDATIONS

Sessions 1–3 (Modules 0–2)

PRACTITIONER

Sessions 4–6 (Modules 3–5)

ADVANCED

Sessions 7–8 (Modules 6–7)

SESSION SCHEDULE

Times assume a 9:00 start. Shift the whole block to fit your schedule (an afternoon or evening run works the same way). Lesson titles link to the lesson pages on the course site.

SESSION 1 Your First Win

FOUNDATIONS

By end of session: find your way around Photoshop, then open, crop, adjust, and export a photo without ever changing the original, first on a practice file and then on a photo of your own.

Deliverable: one photo, fixed and exported (Module 0)

PART 1 Orientation → Module 0 · Your First Win

9:00–11:00

9:00	Welcome & introductions · What you shoot or make, and one image you'd love to be able to create
9:15	Course orientation · The project-driven path, the Recipes library, journaling, growth mindset
9:35	Setup check + workspace tour · Open a practice file; the four neighborhoods; reset the workspace
9:55	L01 Fix & Export One Photo · Demo + guided build on a practice file, then the self-check; everyone exports a JPG
10:45	Break

PART 2 Module 0 · Your First Win

11:00–12:00

11:00	LAB Hands-on: the same loop, independently, on your own photo · The lesson's solo variation; the instructor coaches instead of demoing
11:35	Share-out · Before/after eyeball toggles: proof the original is untouched
11:50	First journal entry & wrap · Why Photoshop, and one image you dream of making; Session 2 preview

SESSION 2 Foundations

FOUNDATIONS

By end of session: read a layer stack, paint a mask, cut a subject out onto a mask, and heal away spots and distractions on a separate layer.

Deliverable: a messy photo cleaned up (Module 1)

PART 1 Module 1 · Foundations (I)

9:00–11:05

9:00	Warm-up: recall the Module 0 loop · Open → Save .psd → Crop → Adjust → Save → Export
9:10	L02 The Layer Stack & Your First Mask · Black hides, white reveals: rescue a washed-out sky
10:00	L03 Selections That Hold Up · Select Subject, Select & Mask, output to a layer mask, a new background
10:50	Break

PART 2 Module 1 · Foundations (II)

11:05–12:00

11:05	L04 Cleaning Up: Spots, Distractions & Edges · Heal, remove & clone on a retouch layer, then export the Module 1 deliverable
11:55	Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 3 Light & Color

FOUNDATIONS

By end of session: develop a flat photo in Camera Raw, shape its tone and color with Curves, and finish a grade in which every decision is still re-editable.

Deliverable: a flat photo graded and alive (Module 2)

PART 1 Module 2 · Light & Color (I)

9:00–10:52

9:00		Welcome & Module 1 recap · Black hides, white reveals; screen-settings reminder
9:08	L05	The Develop Step: Camera Raw · Demo, lab & check: Smart Object, white balance, global tone; save grade-working.psd
9:50	L06	Curves: Precise Tone & Color · Demo, lab & check: S-curve, channel grades, a masked Curves layer
10:40		Break

PART 2 Module 2 · Light & Color (II)

10:52–12:00

10:52	L07	Smart Objects & Finishing the Grade · Demo, lab & check: Smart Filters, lossless transforms, export module2-grade-final.jpg
11:37	LAB	Grade gallery: volunteers toggle the Smart Filter eye for a before/after
11:50		Wrap-up, journal & Session 4 preview · Bring a consented portrait next time

SESSION 4 Retouching

PRACTITIONER

By end of session: retouch a portrait naturally: heal only the temporary, even the tone with frequency separation, and sculpt the face with dodge & burn.

Deliverable: a natural portrait retouch (Module 3). Bring a portrait you have permission to edit and show.

PART 1 Module 3 · Retouching (I)

9:00–10:54

9:00		Welcome, recap & ground rules · Consent and respect; "great retouching is invisible"
9:10	L08	Natural Skin: Heal, Don't Erase · Demo, lab & check: temporary vs permanent, a retouch layer, Spot Healing & Healing Brush
9:47	L09	Frequency Separation · Demo, lab & check: Stamp Visible, LOW for color, HIGH for texture
10:42		Break

PART 2 Module 3 · Retouching (II)

10:54–12:00

10:54	L10	Dodge & Burn: Sculpting Light · Demo, lab & check: a 50% gray Soft Light layer, eyes & teeth, export portrait-final.jpg
11:39	LAB	Critique: "Would they recognize themselves?" (volunteers; talk about the edit, not the face)
11:52		Wrap-up, journal & Session 5 preview

SESSION 5

Compositing

PRACTITIONER

By end of session: cut a subject out cleanly, match it to a new scene's light and color, ground it with shadows, and export one believable photograph.

Deliverable: a believable two-image composite (Module 4)

PART 1 Module 4 · Compositing (I)

9:00–10:47

9:00		Open & recap · Goal: one believable photograph
9:05	L11	Cut It Out Cleanly · Demo, lab & check: Refine Hair, Refine Edge Brush, Decontaminate Colors
9:50	L12	Make It Belong: Match Light & Color · Demo, lab & check: Place Embedded, then clipped brightness, color & contrast
10:35		Break

PART 2 Module 4 · Compositing (II)

10:47–12:00

10:47	L13	Ground It & Grade It · Demo, lab & check: contact & cast shadows, haze, one unifying grade, export
11:42	LAB	Gallery & critique: the squint test; name the shadow direction
11:55		Wrap & journal · Keep the JPG: it can be the Module 5 poster's hero image

SESSION 6

Design & Type

PRACTITIONER

By end of session: design a finished poster with clear type hierarchy, crisp vector shapes, and restrained layer styles, exported correctly for print or screen.

Deliverable: a finished poster (Module 5)

PART 1 Module 5 · Design & Type (I)

9:00–10:47

9:00		Open & recap · Today your images get words: the finished-poster goal
9:05	L14	Type & Hierarchy · Demo, lab & check: a type layer per line, reading order, Character panel, type on a path
9:50	L15	Shapes & the Pen · Demo, lab & check: frame, badge with Path Operations, one Pen shape, a path reused as a mask
10:35		Break

PART 2 Module 5 · Design & Type (II)

10:47–12:00

10:47	L16	Layer Styles & the Poster · Demo & lab: live styles, Smart Objects, a hero image, export for screen (print version as homework)
11:45	LAB	Poster gallery: name the 1st, 2nd & 3rd thing you read
11:55		Wrap & journal · Practitioner tier complete

SESSION 7 AI & Speed + Capstone Brief

ADVANCED

By end of session: remove and add content with Generative Fill, reframe with Generative Expand, batch-process a folder with an Action, and choose your capstone brief.

Deliverables: a generative edit plus an automated batch (Module 6) · homework: capstone plan, moodboard & most of the build

PART 1 Module 6 · AI & Speed (I)

9:00–10:34

9:00 Open & sign-in check · Signed in, online, generative credits available

9:08 **L17** Generative Fill · Demo & lab: remove with an empty prompt, add by describing, refine; prompts, limits & honesty

9:48 **L18** Generative Expand & Reframe · Demo & lab: uncrop, reframe to a ratio, check the seam at 100%

10:22 Break

PART 2 Module 6 · AI & Speed (II) → Capstone

10:34–12:00

10:34 **L19** Actions, Batch & Droplets · Demo & lab: record an Action, batch a practice folder into web JPGs, build a droplet

11:36 Check & journal · The three lessons' self-checks together

11:48 **CAP** **Capstone homework launch:** the six briefs (Lesson 20) · Homework: commit to a brief, plan it, and build most of it (Lesson 21)

SESSION 8 Capstone: Review, Present & Ship

ADVANCED

By end of session: finish a self-directed portfolio piece in an organized, non-destructive file, present it in context, and critique it against the course rubric.

Deliverable: a self-directed portfolio piece, presented (Module 7)

PART 1 Module 7 · Plan Review & Studio

9:00–11:02

9:00 **L20** Choose Your Brief & Plan: plan review · Pairs: brief, moodboard & current file; "What do you expect this to look like?"; set a studio goal

9:20 **LAB** **Studio** (Lesson 21): finish the piece, then ship prep · Step back, 100% pass, clean master; last 10 min: export the delivery file and write the statement (Lesson 22)

10:50 Break

PART 2 Module 7 · Present & Ship

11:02–12:00

11:02 **CAP** **Presentations & peer critique** (Lesson 22): about 4 minutes each · Present, room squint test, two reviewers (one glow, one grow), presenter notes

11:52 Course close · Where to go next, the one idea to keep, the final journal prompt

COURSE DETAILS

■ Requirements

- ◆ **No prior Photoshop experience:** absolute beginners welcome
- ◆ Comfortable finding, copying, and organizing files and folders
- ◆ A Windows or macOS computer that runs **Adobe Photoshop 2025 or newer** (the current release is recommended); the desktop app, not Photoshop on the web or iPad
- ◆ An **Adobe account** with a plan that includes Photoshop (a free trial can cover a 4-day intensive, not an eight-week run)
- ◆ **Internet access and generative credits** for Session 7 (Generative Fill and Expand run in the cloud)
- ◆ A mouse (strongly recommended over a trackpad); a pen tablet is optional

■ What's Provided

- ◆ A **setup guide** to complete before Session 1
- ◆ The full **22-lesson** course workbook (yours to keep)
- ◆ **Practice files** for every lab, so you are never stuck without a suitable photo
- ◆ The online **Recipes library:** 25 quick, standalone how-to cards
- ◆ Guided builds in every session, a capstone studio, and peer critique
- ◆ A finished, exported piece from every session, plus a presented portfolio piece

■ Bring Your Own Photos

- ◆ **S1:** an everyday photo that is a little dark or crooked (a practice file is provided too)
- ◆ **S2:** a landscape with a sky, a photo with one clear subject, and a "messy" photo with dust or a distraction
- ◆ **S3:** a flat or off-color photo (overcast or indoor is ideal)
- ◆ **S4:** a portrait of someone who has agreed to be retouched and shown in class (a self-portrait works)
- ◆ **S5:** two images: a subject on a plain-ish background, and a scene to place it in
- ◆ **S6:** optional: a photo for the poster's hero image (your Module 4 composite works well)
- ◆ **S7:** a photo with a distraction and open space, a tightly cropped photo, and a folder of copies to batch
- ◆ **S8:** your capstone file, built as homework from images you own or have the right to use

■ Assessment

- ◆ **Session deliverables:** each module's finished piece, checked against its lesson's Project Completion Checklist
- ◆ **Learning journal:** a short entry after every lesson, revisited at the capstone
- ◆ **Capstone:** planned, built, presented, and scored on a published rubric: the six rows of Lesson 22's Honest Critique (focal point, light & color, edges & masks, type, believability, the squint test) plus plan, file, and presentation
- ◆ **Completion:** every session deliverable submitted, plus a capstone with no rubric row below 2 of 3
- ◆ Below the bar? Targeted feedback and a resubmission

What You'll Be Able to Do

Graduates leave with a portfolio of finished pieces and the habits to keep making more.

- ✓ Work non-destructively with layers, masks, adjustment layers & Smart Objects
- ✓ Grade light and color with Camera Raw and Curves
- ✓ Build a composite that looks like a single photograph
- ✓ Use Generative Fill & Expand, and automate with Actions and batches
- ✓ Make clean selections and believable cutouts
- ✓ Retouch a portrait naturally with frequency separation and dodge & burn
- ✓ Design with type, shapes, and layer styles
- ✓ Plan, build, and present a self-directed portfolio piece

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v1.0 · 8 sessions · 24 hours